

To Billy and Blain. and Dairne
Did you know that your great,
great, great grand father was
gored to death by a bull?
He was my grand father on
my mother's side.

His name was Mathias Donald.
His parents came from Danvers
Germany and they settled a
short time in Pennsylvania
and then with friends and
relatives came to Kansas and
helped establish the town of
Danvers Kansas

Mathias was married twice
and had a large family of
children several died in
infancy. Several grew up and
are listed in the Schmidt "family
tree".

Mathias homesteaded a farm
four miles south of Danvers
Kansas on the Little Blue
river. Half of the farm was

next to the river mostly wooded that was farmed as the trees were cleared away. The other half of the farm was hilly ground and called pasture land.

He was a farmer and also a cattle buyer and raises and feeds cattle. Cattle were mostly grass fed several years and then shut up in feed lots and stuffed with corn to make them fat and heavier to bring more money when they were sold to the slaughter houses.

It was told that at some time in his life he had driven a freight wagon from Omaha to ~~Chapin~~ ^{Cheliso} ~~Cheliso~~ ^{Cheliso} Kansas. There were no roads then only trails and Indians and buffaloes still roamed

-37-

the plains. There were no bridges so the freighters had to find ways to cross the streams and rivers ~~they had to cross~~ and of course they were out in all kinds of weather weeks at a time.

My mother told me that bands of indians would come to their house and be allowed to come into the house and they would try to trade anything they had (which wasn't much) for anything they liked even food that was on the table. They were friendly indians and they tried to treat them nice but were a little afraid of them as there were many bad stories told about them.

Another story was that a roving band had found a dead horse that had been thrown in a ditch.

and they cooked and ate it
and partied late into
the night.

The Donalds were very
influential and popular and
are recorded in the Washington
County Centennial on the
early history of the county.

The original Donald home
was a small white stone
house made from stone on
the hill side but was re-
modeled but is now much
the same as I can remember
seventy or more years ago.

As the buffalo were
being killed off cattle were
introduced and raised.
Cows could be turned loose
on open range and they would
have calves and they would
grow and they themselves
have calves with practically

no care or attention. Cattle
were branded with a hot
iron with an insignia
of the owner and every year
or so could be "Rounded up"
and the calves branded and
some of the stock sold to
the slaughter houses. Cattle
raising is still a big
industry in the U. S. today.

The Owyath homestead had
a large feed lot and they "fed
out" a lot of cattle year after
year. As you know "I hope"
a bull is necessary to a
herd of cattle and some of
these scuttles were notoriously
crazy and would try to
protect their herd from
any intrusion. It has
long been said that anythin'
red would make them mad,
if it was named at them.

many pastures with cattle
in them but was always
on the alert for any bad
bull in the herd.

On one particular day my
grandfather had occasion to
go in the feed lot alone
and when they heard him
call they came and chased
the bull away but he had
got him down and stopped
on him and he died
shortly afterward.

They said it was the largest
funeral in Washington County
and the parade of wagons
and buggies and on horse
back and walking was over
four miles long from the
home to the cemetery in
Hammer.

He was considered a



7
fairly rich man, for that
time land owned several
sections of land in western
Kansas although land in
those days could be bought
very cheap. His estate was
estimated at Eighty thousand
dollars but as I said he had
many children so the shares
were quite small. My mother
took a half-section of land
as her share.

He is, in my belief, the
most outstanding man in
our family history.